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Johnny Cade: A Story of Choice Versus Destiny

Some things in life are simply out of one's control, such as the family they were born into, or the surroundings they grew up in. While this is the case, everyone and anyone still has the power to decide how they act within these circumstances. William Ernest Henley's poem "Invictus" deeply explores this idea of choice versus destiny. Similarly in the novel *The Outsiders* by S.E. Hinton, Johnny Cade is a Greaser who seems to have won the lottery when it comes to bad luck. The scrawny 16 year old yearns for a world of love, yet is neglected by his parents and constantly targeted by a rival gang. Apart from a few friends, Johnny is left to deal with the hardships of life all on his own. Through its theme of "one has the power to shape their future, regardless of their current state", the poem "Invictus" perfectly encapsulates the character arc of Johnny.

In Hinton's novel *The Outsiders*, life throws many misfortunes at Johnny, many of which others don't have to deal with. In the beginning of the novel, Ponyboy introduces Johnny along with the other Greasers, explaining, "If you can picture a little dark puppy that has been kicked too many times and is lost in a crowd of strangers, you'll have Johnny...He had a nervous, suspicious look in his eyes, and that beating he got from the Socs didn't help matters. He was the gang's pet, everyone's kid brother. His father was always beating him up, and his mother ignored

him” (Hinton 11-12). In this description, Johnny is portrayed as a helpless boy who has no choice but to accept all the adversity in life. None of the challenges he is forced to face were a result of his own actions; after all, everyone is innocent when they are born. To make the situation worse, Johnny has little support and love in the world except from a few of the Greasers. All in all, Johnny feels powerless when it comes to conquering his fears and achieving what he really wants: a life in a world of love.

Even so, Johnny develops into a more confident and independent character later in the novel. One example of this is when he realizes that children were trapped inside a burning church. Ponyboy recalls Johnny risking his life to rescue them, describing, “One was screaming his head off, and Johnny yelled, ‘Shut up! We’re goin’ to get you out!’ The kid looked surprised and quit hollering. I blinked myself– Johnny wasn’t behaving at all like his old self...He wasn’t scared either. That was the only time I can think of when I saw him without that defeated, suspicious look in his eyes. He looked like he was having the time of his life” (Hinton 92). Here, Johnny’s actions reflect the major growth he experiences throughout the story. Whereas the old Johnny would have been timid, the new Johnny not only triumphs over his own past, but fights for the future of others as well. As seen throughout the novel *The Outsiders*, Johnny’s character strongly embodies the lesson of taking control of one’s destiny regardless of their past adversity.

A similar theme is explored in the poem “Invictus” by William Ernest Henley. The speaker is resilient as he declares, “Under the bludgeonings of chance/My head is bloody, but unbowed” (Henley 7-8). The “bludgeonings of chance” represent the many random misfortunes and hardships that the speaker has gone through in life. The speaker could have chosen to complain about the unfairness of life and give in, but he endures through the pain, keeping his head held up. Many of these ideas correspond to Johnny’s life from *The Outsiders*. Combined

with a brilliant use of alliteration, these lines express that the speaker is resilient through the rough side of life.

The speaker further emphasizes this point later in the poem. In the last four lines, the author writes,

It matters not how strait the gate,

How charged with punishments the scroll,

I am the master of my fate:

I am the captain of my soul (Henley 13-16).

Announcing that his bloodstained past no longer matters, the speaker declares that just because life has not been the most fair to him, it doesn't mean he won't keep going. These lines very much reflect Johnny when he ends his life of victimhood to take his last breath as a hero. Although his ending was short-lived, Johnny nonetheless triumphs over his hardships as he decides to take control of his own destiny. In both the novel and poem, the main character prevails over their past and eventually decides their own fate.

In conclusion, Johnny's character from *The Outsiders* is clearly reflected in the poem "Invictus". Both Johnny and the speaker grapple with the choice of adhering to their misfortunes in life and fighting for a future that they desire. Not everyone is born into a neglectful family, nor is everyone forced to constantly fear being jumped by a rival gang. Nevertheless, given these unfortunate circumstances, Johnny ultimately decides to take charge of his fate and fight for himself and those around him. Every person's life belongs to them and them only; like Johnny and the speaker from "Invictus", everyone possesses the power to shape their own destiny.